Practices of Comparing
A New Research Agenda Between Typological and Historical Approaches

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Comparisons—a ubiquitous tool of powerful thinking? Introduction to a multidisciplinary field of manifold controversies[1]

"It's like comparing apples and oranges"—this is what one might well say when a comparison is deemed to be impossible. This fruit-based example for not being able to compare holds at least in the Anglo-American world; Germans prefer to state the same impossibility by comparing apples and pears (likewise supposed to be in vain). Speaking of comparison in general, the opposite also holds true: You can compare everything with everything—as another quite common saying goes. You definitely can compare apples with oranges. Being fruit, they share a commonality while differing in many other respects. They are truly comparable in terms of their size or shape; their weight, color, taste, health index, origin, and history, the ease of peeling them; their local and global distribution; their economic positions on markets; and their appearances in seventeenth-century paintings or world literature. The comparisons are endless, and the fate of apples, oranges, and pears—being both comparable and incomparable at the same time—might befall human beings as well: They become objects of comparisons and, what is more, they constantly compare themselves to each other. But in the end, more than often, they think of themselves as being truly incomparable.

There is more than one seeming paradox when it comes to comparisons. On the one hand, comparing is surrounded by warnings and prohibitions: You cannot compare this; you must not compare that. This therefore implies an important, even dangerous issue: It addresses and relates things that are different and have to

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be kept separate—be they objects, actions, values, or human beings. A statement in the form of "this cannot be compared" may be just a different version of saying that these things are not the same; but when it comes to love and hate, for example, or to war atrocities and genocides, the much contested statement might also build walls around "incomparable" entities and differences either treasured or abhorred. It marks comparison as an outreaching and overbearing mode of thinking that blurs borders and connects things that may not belong together (or should not be seen next to each other). Respectively, however, the prohibitions and warnings surrounding comparisons classify them as powerful tools of thinking: seeing things as being equal and different at the same time, putting formerly separated things together, or even distorting common ways of thinking.

On the other hand, when you can compare everything with everything, comparisons may lack specificity and contours. Then comparisons are always at hand and may, therefore, seem arbitrary or irrelevant. The omnipresence of comparisons makes them a quite trivial everyday phenomenon—and may turn the warnings and prohibitions into an equally trivial caveat, probably a mere rhetorical game. Everything can be compared with everything—so what?

These two sides of comparisons—their ubiquity and their power as a thinking tool—can be moved and indeed have been moved in different directions. On the one hand, comparing can be considered a ubiquitous activity that is easily at hand and—as a condition of mind—does not require any further investigation. People, while thinking, compare—no matter what. On the other hand, comparing is a socially defined practice that provokes both warnings or prohibitions, and further comparisons (i.e., the discerning, measuring, and judging of similarities and differences) may be an important and powerful tool for evaluating things, persons, and groups; for demonstrating relations of power; and—last not least—for arguing, convincing, and making decisions. You should always compare, but, at the same time, you should always be aware of things that cannot be compared. The more one thinks about it, the more complicated things become. Are these imperatives (compare and don't compare) just two sides of a complicated matter, a theoretical aporia, or a language game (in the sense of Ludwig Wittgenstein)? How could we better understand what comparisons as a condition of mind and comparing as a social practice define?

Since Aristotle, comparison has been part of rhetoric, a proper tool to demonstrate and persuade,[2] but also an ingredient of logical thinking through classifying and concluding, judging and measuring, as well as detecting and sorting out sameness and difference between all kinds of related (and seemingly unrelated) entities and matters. As a method of adequate thinking, comparison elevated itself to a

2 Cf. Aristotle, *Rhetoric*. Book III, Chap. 4 (1406–1407) and 11 (1412–1413). See also Quintilian, *Institutes of Oratory*, 1, 105, 353.

scientific method in the sciences, especially as a logically proven instrument of knowledge, judgment, and cognition. In his *Regulae ad directionem ingenii* (1628/29), René Descartes builds science and its methods on the foundation that "in all reasoning it is only by means of comparison that we attain an exact knowledge of the truth."[3] This advice was crystallized into a set of methods by gradually specializing academic disciplines in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries that were formed and understood themselves as explicit comparative sciences in the fields of anatomy, religion, law, linguistics, philology, ethnography, and anthropology.[4]

As a self-evident cognitive tool and as a clear-cut method in scientific contexts, comparison gained attention as a quite basic activity of thinking as well as a propaedeutic instrument for doing scientific research. Psychology established social comparison research as an analysis of how people compare themselves to each other in social settings.[5] Cognitive sciences have started to examine those brain-based comparative perceptions that are processed when humans discern and select objects in general.[6] Theories and methodologies of specialized sciences have tried to reflect on their tools of comparison by shaping and refining the ways to identify and measure the similarities and differences between their scientific objects and fields.[7]

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3 René Descartes, Rules for the Direction of the Mind, in: John Cottingham/Robert Stoothoff/Dugald Murdoch (eds.), *The Philosophical Writings of Descartes*, vol. I, Cambridge 1985, 57. The statement plays a famous role in the distinction between the "episteme," the age of resemblances, and the early modern age of representation in Michel Foucault, *The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences*, New York 1970, 51. For a later scientific validation of the general standpoint that thinking is comparing, see, for example, Max Schießl, Untersuchungen über die Ideenassociation und ihren Einfluß auf den Erkenntnisakt, in: *Zeitschrift für Philosophie und philosophische Kritik*, Neue Folge 61 (1872), 247–282, see 257.

4 See Guy Jucquois/Christophe Vielle (eds.), *Le comparatism dans les sciences de l'homme*, Brussels 2000; Peter Zima, *Vergleichende Wissenschaften*, Tübingen 2000; Michael Eggers, *Vergleichendes Erkennen. Zur Wissenschaftsgeschichte und zur Epistemologie des Vergleichs und zur Genealogie der Komparatistik*, Heidelberg 2016.

5 A now classic account is Leon Feistinger, A Theory of Social Comparison Processes, in: *Human Relations* 7 (1954), 117–140. See Jerry Suls/Ladd Wheeler (eds.), *Handbook of Social Comparison. Theory and Research*, New York 2000.

6 See, for example, Christian H. Poth, *Episodic visual cognition: Implications for object and short-term recognition*, URL: https://pub.uni-bielefeld.de/publication/2911816 [last accessed December 9, 2019].

7 Cf. Joachim Matthes, The Operation called "Vergleichen", in: Joachim Matthes (ed.), *Zwischen den Kulturen? Die Sozialwissenschaften vor dem Problem des Kulturvergleichs*, Göttingen 1992, 75-99; Hartmut Kaelble, *Der Historische Vergleich. Eine Einführung zum 19. und 20. Jahrhundert*, Frankfurt a.M./New York 1999; Ann Laura Stoler, Tense and Tender Ties: The Politics of Comparison in North American History and (Post)Colonial Studies, in: *The Journal of American History* 88 (3/2001), 829-865; Hans-Gerhard Haupt, Comparative History, in: *International Encyclopedia of the Social and Behavioral Sciences* 4, Amsterdam 2001, 2397–2403; Hans-Gerhard Haupt/Jürgen Kocka (eds.), *Comparative and Transnational History. Central Eu-*

So far, comparisons have been discussed as a mental activity or as being involved in theories and methodologies. With a few exceptions that we shall come back to later on, comparisons *per se* were, for a long time, not even considered a problem. This is remarkable, because related antonyms such as incomparability, noncommensurability, or incommensurability have been disputed broadly and controversially in philosophy and the theory of science ever since Thomas Kuhn's intervention regarding the structure of scientific revolutions in the 1960s.[8] Apart from these discussions, comparisons as an object of investigation, their history, and their seeming paradoxes have not gained similar attention for a long time. This changed for the first time in recent years when scholars from different disciplines began to think critically about the simultaneity of the so-called "ages of discovery" and the emergence of comparative sciences in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. What has been called the onset of "Western modernity" not only relies on numerous encounters with non-European cultures and civilizations, but is also intertwined with comparisons or, in other words, with the power, the forces, the causes, the functions, and the effects of comparisons.[9] Scholars have begun to ask whether comparison as a scientific and cultural tool that flourished in Europe's imperial era might be a predominately Western and European preoccupation, even a kind of obsession that is closely tied to enlightened and colonial ways of understanding, exploring, and dominating the world.[10] Starting with the notion of progress and civilization as temporal measures of comparing who is ahead and who

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ropean Approaches and New Perspectives, New York/Oxford 2009; Thomas Welskopp, Vergleichende Geschichte, in: *Europäische Geschichte Online*, URL: http://ieg-ego.eu/de/threads/theorien-und-methoden/vergleichende-geschichte [last accessed December 9, 2019]; Ann Christiane Solte-Gresser/Hans-Jürgen Lüsebrink/Manfred Schmeling (eds.), *Zwischen Transfer und Vergleich. Theorien und Methoden der Literatur- und Kulturbeziehungen aus deutsch-französischer Perspektive*, Stuttgart 2013; Annette Simonis/Linda Simonis (eds.), *Kulturen des Vergleichens*, Heidelberg 2016.

8 Cf. Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, Chicago 1962; Carl G. Hempel, *Grundzüge der Begriffsbildung in der empirischen Wissenschaft*, Düsseldorf 1974, 83–86; Ruth Chang, *Making Comparisons Count*, London/New York 2002; Paul Borghossian, *Fear of Knowledge: Against Relativism and Constructivism*, Oxford 2006; Martin Carrier, Incommensurability and Empirical Comparability: The Case of the Phlogiston Theory, in: Peter Gärdenfors/Jan Woleński/Katarzyna Kijania-Placek (eds), *In the Scope of Logic, Methodology and Philosophy of Science*, Dordrecht 2002, 551–564.

9 See Pheng Cheah, Grounds of Comparison, in: *Diacritics* 29 (1999), 3–18; Pheng Cheah, The Material World of Comparison, in: Rita Felski/Susan Stanford Friedman (eds.), *Comparison: Theories, Approaches, Uses*, Baltimore 2013, 168–190; Angelika Epple/Walter Erhart (eds.), *Die Welt beobachten. Praktiken des Vergleichens*, Frankfurt a. M./New York 2015; Willibald Steinmetz (ed.), *The Force of Comparison. A New Perspective on Modern European History and the Contemporary World*, New York/Oxford 2019.

10 Cf. Natalie Melas, *All the Difference in the World. Postcoloniality and the Ends of Comparison*, Stanford 2007; Walter Mignolo, On Comparison: Who is Comparing What and Why? In: Rita Fel-

is lagging behind,[11] the quantitative comparisons of populations and economic data went on to create a world society that is finally united and charted by comparison through numbers, statistics, and graphs.[12] Today, comparing is not just an all-pervasive global instrument. The practice of instant digital comparisons along with the proliferation of rankings, lists, and comparative evaluations is beginning to dominate—or even tyrannize—private and public lives in the digital age.[13] Whereas sociology points to an increase of comparative means as a side effect of or a stimulus for modernization processes—be it through the development of media and technology or the emergence of culture as a field of second-order observation and therefore comparison[14]—postcolonial critics have argued that comparing has always put and kept those persons, groups, and agents in power who actually decide what is worth comparing, whose perspective is adopted, and who, by starting to compare, set the standards and norms that are automatically involved in the act of comparing.[15] Does that indicate that comparative methodologies must be thrown overboard?

Before making a momentous decision, we should take a closer look at the terminology. A comparison might be described as a logical operation that puts into perspective two entities, the two *comparata*, in respect to a *tertium comparationis*. A comparison carried out by actors, in contrast, is a socially determined activity. Its distinctive feature is that actors assume comparability and then relate similarities and differences between two or more entities. The assumption of comparability seems to be a crucial point. Only if actors feel that apples and pears *are* comparable, they will carry out comparisons. In other words, you truly can compare everything with everything, but you can do so only, first, when you assume comparability;

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ski/Susan Stanford Friedman (eds.), *Comparison: Theories, Approaches, Uses*, Baltimore 2013, 99–111.

11 See the now classical work by Johannes Fabian, *Time and the Other*, New York 1983.

12 Cf. Sally Engle Merry, Measuring the World. Indicators, Human Rights, and Global Governance, in: *Current Anthropology* 52 (2011), 83–95; Bettina Heintz/Tobias Werron, Wie ist Globalisierung möglich? Zur Entstehung globaler Vergleichshorizonte am Beispiel von Wissenschaft und Sport, in: *Kölner Zeitschrift für Soziologie und Sozialpsychologie* 63 (2011), 359–394; Bettina Heintz, Welterzeugung durch Zahlen. Modelle politischer Differenzierung in internationalen Statistiken 1948-2010, in: Cornelia Bohn/Arno Schubbach/Leon Wansleben (eds.), *Welterzeugung durch Bilder*, Stuttgart 2012, 7–39.

13 Cf. Steffen Mau, *Das metrische Wir. Über die Quantifizierung des Sozialen*, Berlin 2017; Bettina Heintz, "Wir leben im Zeitalter der Vergleichung". Perspektiven einer Soziologie des Vergleichs, in: *Zeitschrift für Soziologie* 45 (2016), 305–323.

14 Cf. Niklas Luhmann, Kultur als historischer Begriff, in: Niklas Luhmann, *Gesellschaftsstruktur und Semantik* 4, Frankfurt a. M. 1999, 31–54; Bettina Heintz, Numerische Differenz. Überlegungen zu einer Soziologie des (quantitativen) Vergleichs, in: *Zeitschrift für Soziologie* 39 (2010), 162–181.

15 Rajagopalan Radhakrishnan, Why Compare?, in: *New Literary History* 40 (2009), 453–475.

and, second, when you find an adequate *tertium comparationis*. Both features depend heavily on the societal and historical context. Every comparison is made only with respect to a perspective from which the sorting out of differences and similarities makes sense. Comparing is based on that which the particular comparisons are aimed toward, the *tertium comparationis* that is set up or implicitly engaged within the whole process of comparing.[16] Apples, oranges, and pears might be compared, but this is done very differently by traders, sellers, or consumers who choose very different purposes and *tertia* for their comparative actions.

Reconsidering comparisons as practices of comparing—with a history of their own

Far exceeding a mere mental activity and a methodological instrument, we suggest that comparisons should be reconsidered as practices of comparing that have a history of their own with different actors, multifaceted deployments, and often unprecedented effects—all to be studied in their own right. Comparing is not an activity that could be analyzed as a logical operation that would start with the characteristics of the *comparata*. Comparing is shaped (though not determined) by societal practices. We understand practices as repeatable patterns of action that, at the same time, enable or even provoke comparisons and shape them. However, practices are not completely fixed or stable; they depend on being performed by actors. If an actor carries out comparisons, she or he actualizes a specific practice; and simply because of a time index, every repetition also shifts the practice slightly. If other actors take up the shift—willingly or not—practices might change. The self-evidence of the seemingly objective use of comparisons in everyday life, the media, the sciences, and the humanities has actually obscured the fact that comparing is not neutral or innocent, but is always interwoven with the interests and perspectives of the ones who compare and is related to the situations and contexts in which comparisons are made. How *tertia comparationis* are taken up implicitly for different purposes—how, for example, they may be altered or left behind while the objects of comparison stay the same—is in no way self-evident or objective. The postcolonial critique has convincingly questioned the historical uses of comparison as a quasineutral tool of Western hegemony and domination. It even went so far as to ask whether comparing itself could be a predominately Eurocentric instrument of thinking and judging that might be replaced by other means in order to renounce the normative implications of comparison: by juxtaposition while cut-

16 Cf. Andreas Mauz/Hartmut von Sass (eds.), *Hermeneutik des Vergleichs. Strukturen, Anwendungen und Grenzen komparativer Verfahren*, Würzburg 2011.

ting out judgment and evaluation,[17] by stopping at the mere acknowledgment of "comparability,"[18] and by emphasizing "lateral comparisons" in order to balance the "frontal comparisons" of "us" and "them" as practiced in much traditional as well as in postcolonial anthropology.[19] Postcolonial approaches, however, more often than not, have repeated the dichotomies of the "colonial powers" and the "colonial other" within their studies. This repetition has to do with the postcolonial interest in analyzing "othering," as Homi K. Bhabha would have it.[20] We would like to suggest a new research agenda that, instead of criticizing the methods and the construction of the Other through comparison, focuses on the very practices of comparing. The analysis of comparative practices makes it possible to gain a better understanding of both the doing of differences and the doing of similarities. It helps reveal the constructed relation between the two and puts the dynamics of comparing in the foreground. Sometimes actors do not mention, and sometimes they do not even realize, that comparing puts differences and similarities evenly in perspective. Comparing is a "relationing" activity that goes way beyond stating mere differences. As a consequence, "othering" might appear as an extreme form of comparing—a form that might point exclusively to differences in respect to a specific *tertium*, but that, nevertheless, relies primarily on the broad assumption of comparability.

We could summarize so far in two points:

1. With the postcolonial critique at the latest, it is the phenomena of comparing itself that comes into view. Instead of comparison as an instrument or tool, be it cognitive, socially or scientifically, instead of the substantive and the entity of "comparison," we rather should take the verb and thereby the action of "comparing" into account. Comparing as a social and historical practice is always bound up with actors and agencies that perform the comparisons and connect them with their purposes and possible outcomes—intended or not. At the end of the day, the question of who is comparing and why actors compare becomes more important than the objects that are actually compared. Instead of objects ever waiting for all possible kinds of comparisons, there are actors who actually start the comparing process while charging it with purposes and shifting *tertia comparationis*.

While doing comparisons, actors are never free from their normative background and the historical context in which comparisons are situated. As a prac-

17 Cf. Susan Stanford Friedman, Why not Compare?, in: Rita Felski/Susan Stanford Friedman (eds.), *Comparison: Theories, Approaches, Uses*, Baltimore 2013, 34–45.

18 Natalie Melas, Merely Comparative, in: *PMLA* 128 (2013), 652–659.

19 Matei Candea, Going Full Frontal: Two Modalities of Comparison in Social Anthropology, in: Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E.R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019, 343–371.

20 Homi Bhabha, *The Location of Culture*, New York 1994.

tice—according to the insights of practice theory[21]—comparing has to be reconsidered not as an individual singular action performed randomly and spontaneously across space and time (and correspondingly hard to grasp), but as part of a framework of comparative practices that have been established through repetition and routines, cultural habits, and historical patterns.[22] As such practices, comparative acts in history are no longer contingent and arbitrary, but are clustered and organized along collective cultural schemes and models according to different framings of actors, groups, classes, nations, or other historical conditions and circumstances.

This shift in perspective also sheds new light on what at first sight appeared to be contradictory or even the paradoxes of comparison: trivial mental activity versus powerful tool of thinking, arbitrariness versus importance, everyday practice versus historical change, or permanence of comparisons versus incomparability. If we analyze the practices of comparing instead, mental activities are no longer the exclusive objects of research. In addition, comparisons are no longer perceived as a neutral instrument that is always at hand with the same devices, but as a practice that changes its rules according to its use and context. As a consequence of the "practical turn" in comparison research, the permanence of comparing and the simultaneous statements of incomparability appear either as divergent tensions or conflicting positions of different actors or as different stages within the very process of comparing. An actor can first assume comparability and then assert incomparability or vice versa. Practices do not necessarily live up to logical operations. The shift in perspective also reacts to the postcolonial critique by slightly changing its point of attack. The analysis of practices of comparing overcomes the analysis of "othering" and thus opens the door for deeper insights into the subtle and not so subtle power relations in comparative situations. The one who claims comparability and detects or determines the perspective, the *tertium comparationis*, holds the power to confront and to evaluate the *comparata*, to keep them either fixed to established normative standards, or to open them up to hitherto unknown perspectives.

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21 Cf. Theodore R. Schatzki, *Social Practices. A Wittgensteinian Approach to Human Activity and the Social*, Cambridge 1996; Andreas Reckwitz, Grundelemente einer Theorie sozialer Praktiken. Eine sozialtheoretische Perspektive, in: *Zeitschrift für Soziologie* 32 (2003), 282–301; Marian Füssel/Tim Neu, Doing Discourse. Diskursiver Wandel aus praxeologischer Perspektive, in: Achim Landwehr (ed.), *Diskursiver Wandel*, Wiesbaden 2010, 213–235.

22 Cf. Johannes Grave, Vergleichen als Praxis. Vorüberlegungen zu einer praxistheoretisch orientierten Untersuchung von Vergleichen, in: Angelika Epple/Walter Erhart (eds.), *Die Welt beobachten. Praktiken des Vergleichens*, Frankfurt a. M./New York 2015, 135–159; Johannes Grave, Comparative Practices and their Implications: The Case of Comparative Viewing, in: Willibald Steinmetz (ed.), *The Force of Comparison. A New Perspective on Modern European History and the Contemporary World*, New York/Oxford 2019, 53–79.

However, the act of comparing, by relating entities, objects, processes, living beings, or humans vis-à-vis a *tertium comparationis*, always challenges the *comparata* involved. To compare distant objects, for instance, always means decontextualizing each object and putting—recontextualizing—it in a new framework with a new *tertium comparationis*. What is more, comparing relies not only on the assumption of comparability but also on a *tertium comparationis* that has also been called the *tertium commune*. The latter expression makes it even clearer that comparing puts similarity and difference into perspective.

2. Comparing as a practice depends not only on the societal context but also on the historical situation. Whereas psychological and sociobiological investigations point to the everlasting pervasiveness of comparing as a quite stable resource of human cognition,[23] the historiographies of comparative sciences have not come to terms with the history of comparing as a social and historical practice whose means, perspectives, and performances may change according to different actors and to either *longues durées* or shorter time periods. "This is the age of comparison!"[24] Friedrich Nietzsche once was quick to diagnose the predicaments of his imperial and antiquarian nineteenth century. However, histories and transformations in the manners and magnitudes of comparisons are quite difficult to assess and to analyze. It is by no means certain and self-explanatory that comparisons writ large started with the "bourgeois" imperial age,[25] and it is equally doubtful whether comparisons have remained the same across time and space over the centuries.

A broadly discussed example might illustrate this: During the so-called "dispute of the New World," long-lasting traditions of comparing were picked up and reframed. The comparison of fruits (and other plants) played a major role when European scholars such as Georges-Louis Leclerc de Buffon or Cornelis de Pauw proved the American climate to have a degenerative effect for humans, animals, and plants alike by also reducing the variety of all living organisms. Comparisons did vary depending on the cultural background. However, the native Mexican Fray

23 See, for example, Bram P. Buunk/Thomas Mussweiler, New Directions in Social Comparison Research, in: *European Journal of Social Psychology* 31 (2001), 467–475. "In its broadest sense, the concept of social comparison—relating one's own features to those of others and vice versa—is an important, if not central, characteristic of human life. […] the need to compare self with others is phylogenetically very old, biologically very powerful, and recognizable in many species." Transferring the concept and the practice of social comparison from humans to animals has recently led to skepticism: See Vanessa Schmitt et al., Do Monkeys Compare Themselves to Others?, in: *Animal Cognition* 19 (2016), 417–428.

24 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, all too human*, Cambridge 1996, 24.

25 For a different perspective see, for example, Anthony Grafton, Comparisons Compared: A Study in the Early Modern Roots of Cultural History, in: Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E. R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019, 18–48.

Francisco Javier Clavijero, for instance, did not hesitate to counter the argument with a different fruit-based comparison: "If America had no pomegranates, lemons &c. it has them now: but Europe never had, has nor can have, chirimoyas, aguacates, musas, chicozapotes, &c."[26] Behind the fruit comparisons, we easily detect that actually something else was being negotiated: the question which world region should be the standard, the norm against which others are to be compared. Who is meant to set the standards for evaluation; who is in the position to decide whether a comparison-based hierarchy is convincing; and who, on the other hand, is forced to react? Whatever the reaction looks like, it is difficult to escape comparisons once they are in the world. However big the differences in standpoints between Clavijero and de Pauw, both scholars were familiar with a long-lasting tradition of comparing the old and the new world. Already in 1609, Inca Garcilaso wrote about comparing America to Europe and the difficulty in countering the imposition of already introduced patterns of comparison. He tried in vain to get rid of comparisons between Europe and America by simply declaring: "every comparison is odious"[27] (as Gary Shaw shows in his contribution to this volume, the saying "comparisons are odious" goes back at least to John Fortescue in 1471 but spread rapidly and with little hindrance in the early modern period). As Garcilaso was claiming incomparability, he nevertheless continued with comparisons. However, long-lasting traditions of comparing Europe to America (tellingly, hardly ever vice versa) should not hide the specific differences and the significant changes in the respective practices. Not only the *comparata* and the *tertia* were changing but also the subjects and the goals, the complexity, and the contexts. Garcilaso around 1600 and de Pauw or Clavijero roughly 200 years later used comparisons very differently insofar as the former tried to render visible the given divine order whereas the latter insisted on proving the truth quite empirically by doing comparisons. For an evaluation of the outcome of comparisons with different *tertia*, de Pauw and Clavijero both needed a measure for weighing the importance of comparisons. What is to be more important: the size of the animals or the variety of species? For an evaluation, a ranking of comparisons so to say, they carried out comparisons of comparisons—a complex and

26 Francisco Javier Clavijero, *History of Mexico*, London 1787, 189. For the dispute of the new world, see: Ottmar Ette, Die 'Berliner Debatte' um die Neue Welt. Globalisierung aus der Perspektive der europäischen Aufklärung, in: Vicente Bernaschina/Kraft, Tobias/Kraume, Anne (eds.), *Globalisierung in Zeiten der Aufklärung. Texte und Kontexte zur 'Berliner Debatte' um die Neue Welt (17./18. Jh.)*. Frankfurt a. M. 2015, 27–55; Hans-Jürgen Lüsebrink, De l'usage de la comparaison dans les écrits des Jésuites sur les Amériques, in: Marc André Bernier/Clorinda Donato/Hans-Jürgen Lüsebrink (eds.), *Jesuit Accounts of the Colonial Americas. Intercultural Transfers, Intellectual Disputes, And Textualities*, Toronto 2014, 418–436.

27 Inca Garcilaso de la Vega,*Primera Parte de los Commentarios Reales*, Lisbon 1609, 56.

reflexive comparison. Without a given divine or natural order, actors themselves were forced to find arguments for searching and proving truth by comparing.[28]

The "dispute of the new world" is but one example illustrating historically differing practices of comparing. There can be no doubt that we need to know far more about it. How can we achieve more knowledge? We would like to put to discussion the combination of a typological endeavor and the investigation of the history of practices of comparing.

Making the new agenda feasible: Typology and the historicity of comparative practices

When postcolonial critique vigorously cast doubt on "Western" practices of comparing, the question of comparison—as a problem; as a way of thinking; and as a contested arena of cultural theory, intercultural perception, and history—arose anew. Despite all the historical vices and defaults of comparison, and even while vigorously facing its rhetorical and ideological bias, comparison is even more in need of a reevaluation that takes the ambivalent status of comparing fully into account.[29] A once colonial practice of comparing may give way to a new "ethics" of comparison based on the "inevitability" and the translation processes of comparison[30] as well as on the "self-relativizing and self-critical function" of a "comparative viewpoint."[31] The European history of comparing may be paralleled and viewed differently by looking at comparative examples and histories of comparison in other equally central parts of the world.[32] The scientific undertakings of comparative re-

28 See for the long-lasting tradition of comparing the new and the old world: Angelika Epple, Comparing Europe and the Americas: The Dispute of the New World between the Sixteenth and Nineteenth Centuries, in: Willibald Steinmetz (ed.), *The Force of Comparison*, New York 2019, 137–163.

29 Haun Saussy, *Are We Comparing Yet? On Standards, Justice, and Incomparability*, Bielefeld 2019.

30 Zhang Longxi, Crossroads, Distant Killing, and Translation: On the Ethics and Politics of Comparison, in: Rita Felski/Susan Stanford Friedman (eds.), *Comparison: Theories, Approaches, Uses*, Baltimore 2013, 46–63, see 59–60.

31 Xie Ming, What Does the Comparative to Theory?, in: *PMLA* 128 (2013), 676–682, see 680.

32 Cf. Marcel Detienne, *Comparing the Incomparable*, Stanford 2008; Xie Ming, *Conditions of Comparison: Reflections on Comparative Intercultural Inquiry*, London 2011; Zhang Longxi, Comparison and Correspondence: Revisiting an Old Idea for the Present Time, in: *Comparative Literature Studies* 53 (4/2016), 766–785.

ligious studies,[33] comparative literature,[34] and anthropology[35] currently seem to be transforming their practices in search for "comparatism as an *ethos*"[36] immediately after it became apparent that the grand theories of comparing "us" and "them"—which had taken center stage in the enlightened and colonial historiographies of religion, history, and anthropology—may have failed altogether. However, what would render such a comparative approach to the history of comparisons feasible? There is a sense of new beginnings in the air. Anil Bhatti and Dorothee Kimmich, for instance, instead of being satisfied with just postcolonial criticism, have recently argued for a new cultural theoretical paradigm that will rely on similarities instead of differences. Their hope to overcome difference-oriented comparisons by a strategic emphasis on similarity shares the moral commitment of postcolonialism.[37] However, we would like to make a slightly different suggestion by taking the full picture of comparing and its dynamic into account. For the time being, we would like to structure all kinds of questions concerning the ethics and the politics of comparison along with the variations, the enabling conditions, the history, and the effects of comparing according to two, partly overlapping bundles of questions that make up a rather typological approach on the one side, and a rather historical approach on the other.

The first bundle of questions deals with typological features and general challenges of comparing without pointing primarily to a temporal index. Given that comparisons are not an innocent tool in the service of objective insights, but a practice shaped by actors situated in a specific societal and historical context, this first bundle of questions points to issues that characterize all practices of com-

33 Cf. Guy G. Stroumsa, History of Religions: The Comparative Moment, in: Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E.R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019, 318–342.

34 Cf. Rey Chow, The Old/New Question of Comparison in Literary Studies: A Post-European Perspective, in: *English Literary History* 71 (2004), 289–311; David Ferris, Why Compare?, in: Ali Behdat/Dominic Thomas (eds.), *A Companion to Comparative Literature*, Malden/Oxford 2011, 28–45; David Porter, The Crisis of Comparison and the World Literature Debate, in: *Profession* 2011, 244–258; Jacob Edmond, No Discipline: An Introduction to "The Indiscipline of Comparison", in: *Comparative Literature Studies* 53 (2016), 647–659.

35 Cf. Richard Handler, The Uses of Incommensurability in Anthropology, in: Rita Felski/Susan Stanford Friedman (eds.), *Comparison: Theories, Approaches, Uses*, Baltimore 2013, 271–291; Matei Candea, *Comparison in Anthropology. The Impossible Method*, Cambridge 2018; Philippe Descola, Anthropological Comparatisms: Generalisations, Symmetrisation, Bifurcation, in: Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E.R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019, 402–417.

36 Stroumsa, History of Religions, 339.

37 Cf. Anil Bhatti/Dorothee Kimmich (eds.), *Similarity. A Paradigme for Culture Theory*, New Delhi 2018.

paring—no matter where and when they are carried out. This would also include reflections on the academic methodology of comparing.

During the last decade, scholars from different disciplines have been discussing the advantages and shortcomings of typologizing comparisons.[38] Most have not referred explicitly to practices of comparing but to comparisons as such.[39] However, their suggestions can also help to typologize the respective practices. When it comes to comparing other humans, groups, and societies, Geoffrey E. R. Lloyd has offered a typology of five "valences" of comparatism as a way of using comparisons.[40] First, "comparatism can be used to claim superiority for the views and practices of those who are doing the comparing."[41] Second, comparing, in turn, may be used to acknowledge the superiority of the other (or at least in certain respects). Third, instead of differences, the commonalities between the two *comparata* may be emphasized. The fourth possibility is to discern only differences, thus stressing incomparability. The fifth valence consists in taking radical difference not as a matter of ranking and judging or not just stopping at incomparability, but looking at comparisons "as a resource for learning something new."[42] Whereas Lloyd tries to put comparing in a typological order, sketching almost ideal types in the sense of Max Weber, Willibald Steinmetz has a similar but more historical typology in mind when he—proceeding from social comparison research—differentiates between comparisons along the two axes of "above/below" and "better/worse" while adding as a third possibility the emphasis on differences and incomparabilities ("just different").[43] In a way, this typology combines the two different bundles of questions that run through this volume, because it also carries a historical index: Whereas comparison as a social scale of "above and below" ranks is quite common in premodern times, better/worse comparisons situated within a competitive framework and incomparability as a sign of uniqueness attributed to persons and individuals are specific modern features of comparative actions.

However, even by establishing typologies of comparisons (and Kirill Postoutenko gives a first-off example of their linguistic possibilities in this volume), the tensions and ambivalences of comparing might not disappear and not even have been fully understood. It is important to note, though, that historical typologies do not

38 See, for instance, Hartmut von Sass, Vergleiche(n). Ein hermeneutischer Rund- und Sinkflug, in: Andreas Mautz/Hartmut von Sass (eds.), *Hermeneutik des Vergleichs*, Würzburg 2011, 25–48.

39 For some thoughts on how to integrate typologies of comparisons into research on practices of comparing, see Grave, Vergleichen als Praxis, 135–159.

40 Geoffrey E. R. Lloyd, *Analogical Investigations. Historical and Cross-Cultural Perspectives on Human Reasoning*, Cambridge 2015, 29–42.

41 Lloyd, *Analogical Investigations*, 30.

42 Lloyd, *Analogical Investigations*, 31.

43 Willibald Steinmetz, Above/below, better/worse, or simply different? Metamorphoses of Social Comparison, 1600–1900, in: Willibald Steinmetz (ed.), *The Force of Comparison, A New Perspective on Modern European History and the Contemporary World*, New York/Oxford 2019, 80–112.

necessarily conflict with the dynamic of comparative practices that—once constructed and performed—moves easily beyond typological confines. Comparing the self and the other in a colonial or postcolonial context, for example, can lead to stereotypes fixing judgments and established norms within a wide array of public and philosophical thinking. Comparing the self and the other can also—almost at the same time—open up horizons that restructure the whole field of comparative knowledge.[44]

The second bundle of questions has a temporal index—in different ways: It looks at practices of comparison built on inherited traditions and incorporated routines or patterns of comparisons thus pointing back to historical continuities. Comparing cultures, for instance, has been a constant focus of attention and a driving force of irritation and transformation from early modern time onward[45] (and Andrea Frisch gives another intriguing example in this volume), and it may well even be Greek ethnography that laid the groundwork for this kind of double-faced comparatism.[46] Comparative practices served to negotiate matters of religion, ethnicity, and law in early modern contact zones. They were also tools to fuel competition in a nationalist and capitalist age—from ethnic uprisings in global conflicts and colonial wars to economic competition or military rivalry and arms races between nation states and superpowers in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

Practices of comparing, however, do not just follow historical traditions and point to continuities; they also change over time. A thought-provoking suggestion by Renaud Gagné and his research group points to different "regimes of comparatism"[47] that have been established over time but that also may have changed

44 A perfect example may be the so-called ages of discovery with multiple encounters of traveling Europeans with non-European civilizations that—with their quite obvious but frequently neglected emphasis on comparison—have been studied in research on world travel literature: See Anthony Pagden, *European Encounters with the New World: From Renaissance to Romanticism*, New Haven 1993; Walter Erhart, Weltreisen, Weltwissen, Weltvergleich – Perspektiven der Forschung, in: *Internationales Archiv für Sozialgeschichte der deutschen Literatur* 42 (2017), 292–321; Christine Peters, Reisen und Vergleichen. Praktiken des Vergleichens in Alexander von Humboldts "Reise in die Äquinoktial-Gegenden des Neuen Kontinents" und Adam Johann von Krusensterns "Reise um die Welt", in: *Internationales Archiv für Sozialgeschichte der deutschen Literatur* 42 (2017), 441–465.

45 See Joan-Pau Rubiés, Comparing Cultures in the Early Modern World: Hierarchies, Genealogies and the Idea of European Modernity, in: Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E.R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019, 116–176.

46 Cf. Raimund Schulz, *Als Odysseus staunte. Die griechische Sicht des Fremden und das ethnographische Vergleichen von Homer bis Herodot*, Göttingen 2020.

47 See Renaud Gagné/Simon Goldhill/Geoffrey E.R. Lloyd (eds.), *Regimes of Comparatism. Frameworks of Comparison in History, Religion and Anthropology*, Leiden/Boston 2019.

slightly or even vanished completely. Most often though, these practices and practice formations, these patterns and regimes of comparing, combine continuities with either ruptures or transformations. This general observation opens the door for challenging questions. In the history of comparisons, what does exactly change: the techniques, the procedures, the topics, the *tertium* (or *tertia*) *comparationis*, the power constellations, or the societal circumstances? Why do comparative practices change and to what end? If we want to write a comprehensive history of comparing, we have to know far more about different historical comparative practices in different cultures or communities or in other kinds of groups that share specific practices. As the example of the scholarly comparisons of the old and the new world in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries has clearly shown, there are, at first sight, many continuities in the history of comparing. However, a closer inspection reveals significant differences that might question or even displace the assumed continuity.

There is an even more complex question about comparative practices that accompanies temporality and addresses the problem and phenomenon of historical change itself: Do practices of comparing trigger historical change? This question is challenging, because the causes of historical change are always manifold. Contingency and nonhuman influences play a major role, and the effects of practices are difficult to prove. Nonetheless, recent research has found strong arguments in support of the assumption that comparing provokes change. This is most obvious in situations of conflict and competition. Discussions about the strength of a hostile army, for instance, are usually based on comparisons—be they comparisons of courage, bodily shape, strategy, or equipment and the power of weapons. Military experts derive instructions for action from these discussions, and these instructions are bound to bring change into the world. In competitive contexts, it is also immediately convincing that comparisons are carried out to legitimize or at least to ask for change. The proliferation of rankings and ratings are another case in point. But does the power of comparative practices also apply to broader historical changes?

Recent research at least supports the idea that the encounters, conflicts, and entanglements of different cultures and the evolution of a comparative scholarly methodology were just two sides of one coin: the making of so-called "Western" modernity. The question whether "Western" modernity is an outcome of specific practices of comparing seems to be a promising thesis. It combines the postcolonial criticism of comparative methodology with a historical finding: In eighteenth-century European academia, comparisons became the basis for methodology in many different disciplines such as anatomy, ethnology, literature, and the like. They also were crucial for coming to terms with new, sometimes challenging, or even confusing and irritating encounters with formerly little or unknown regions, cultures, geographies, people, plants, and animals—both within and outside of

Europe. With comparisons, scholars, adventurers, military experts, explorers, and travelers helped—willingly or not—to naturalize or hide hierarchies by introducing allegedly neutral norms and standards for evaluations. Through comparison, they ordered the world. The decisive point, however, goes beyond this: By ordering the world, the doing of comparison also helped to change the world. Not only the request for equal rights is based on comparisons, also the stress on inequality or unevenness cannot do without comparing. Both ask for change. In the nineteenth century colonial context, imperialism and conquest were legitimized (among others) through the comparison-based argument that people "without history" were in need of education by "people with history."[48] If the importance of comparisons as drivers of historical change applies for a specific time period in a specific part of a specific world region, would that mean that comparing is also an important practice for triggering change in world regions beyond Europe? What would that mean? There are many more questions to be asked about the relation between comparisons and historical change, some of which are taken up in contributions to this volume.

Contributions to this volume

We have sorted the two parts of this book according to the two bundles of questions. The first part includes four chapters that chart the field of comparative practices by taking typological, methodological, and theoretical approaches to comparative speech acts, incomparability, metaphors and poetry, and rankings as a way of comparing by numbers. The second part of the book includes nine contributions that deal with the historicity of comparison. Contributions range from the Middle Ages and the early modern period to the twentieth century and present times; they cover religion; historiography; East–West encounters between Europe, China, and Japan; art and aesthetics; race and slavery systems; politics; and the issue of comparing in the digital age.

The first part starts with preliminary linguistic, semantic, and philosophical reflections on comparison as an operation of thinking, arguing, and speaking. The endeavor to identify comparative utterances and speech acts in languages does not just provide the path to comparison's practices, it also lays the foundation for computer-based methods of detecting comparative phrases within languages and written texts that would enable research on their statistical occurrences and historical transformations. As Kirill Postoutenko shows in his contribution (*Preliminary Typology of Comparative Utterances: A Tree and Some Binaries*), a vast taxonomy of possible comparisons must be taken into account if we want to order and classify different

48 Fabian, *Time and the Other*.

types of comparative utterances. Such typologies—with their examples and highly specified classifications—give a first impression of the wide range of speech acts that are used and performed for comparative purposes. Their data may be taken into consideration each time the historical material of comparative practices has to be structured and scrutinized in written documents.

Whereas a linguistic and semantic archive of possible comparisons composed in this way may be inexhaustible, Hartmut von Sass undertakes the almost opposite move and looks at incomparability as a statement about entities—be they actions, objects, or human beings—that allegedly cannot be compared at all (*Incomparability. A Tentative Guide for the Perplexed*). Also starting with semantic, linguistic, and, this time, philosophical and logical-analytical observations, von Sass shows with great care that the assertion of incomparability—the very opposite of the common-sense statement that everything can be compared with everything—is hard to maintain in a strict logical or structural sense. If objects or statements could be said to be incomparable to each other, the realm and the range, even the very practices of comparison, might have been left and abandoned altogether. Whereas noncommensurability—putting objects together that have nothing in common—is a synonym for "incomparability" (but usually is just the starting point of comparisons to come), incommensurability is the outcome of bringing up so many similarities and differences between objects that an overall comparison is no longer possible.[49] Whereas statements about the principal incomparability of two or more things need to be specified or just remain problematic, a "performative incomparability"—according to Hartmut von Sass—is widely used to address the most important moral, personal, and political issues. What incomparability loses on the side of logical thinking, it clearly gains as a performative practice turning incomparability and incommensurability into a rhetoric and a discourse on shared and contested values among couples and groups, communities and societies.

The contributions of Kirill Postoutenko and Hartmut von Sass both point to the fact that characteristics and descriptions of the linguistic and philosophical structure, the very "nature" of comparison, are almost impossible to have as long as the performative uses of comparing are not taken into account. The paradoxes of comparison as a speech act and as a language game make sense or break down only when the practice and the actors of comparing gain full-blown attention. What is characterized as a problem of proper definition, as a loss or a circuit of never-ending efforts for clear-cut and all-encompassing definitions and typologies, turns into an important aspect for research on the historical, social, and cultural functions of comparative practices.

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49 We owe this clarification to Martin Carrier. On "incommensurability" see Martin Carrier, Changing Laws and Shifting Concepts. On the Nature and Impact of Incommensurability, in: *Boston Studies in the Philosophy of Science* 216 (2001), 65–90.

From early on, ever since *comparatio* was coined a rhetorical device, metaphors and similes have gained attention as the smallest and maybe purest form of comparisons. These and other rhetorical and literary comparisons constantly move between the world as it is and the possibilities of creating a fictional or poetic world of its own. As Walter Erhart shows in his contribution (*Odysseus, Blackbirds, and Rain Barrels: Literature as a Comparative Practice*), the "semantic innovations" (Paul Ricœur) provided by literary comparisons disclose relations that have not been there before. Literature and poetry extend the range and the dynamics of comparing not only by doing comparisons on microlevels such as metaphors and similes, especially in poetry, but also by comparing literary figures and narratives throughout literary history and world literature.

Whereas metaphors, poetry, and fictional narratives create new worlds and worldviews by the world-disclosing activities of their comparative practices, statistics and rankings, quite on the opposite side, seem to register and actually narrow down the world as it is by displaying comparisons by numbers. However, although rankings and graphs seem to represent the peak of neutrality and objectivity, they, nevertheless, do not just collect facts and classify realities but construct their competitive fields while simultaneously just pretending to describe them. The examples in Tobias Werron's and Leopold Ringel's contribution—art, sports, and university rankings—quite tellingly demonstrate that rankings have a history of their own that is closely linked to the emergence of modernity and the rise of fast changing markets, publics, and technologies (*Where Do Rankings Come From? A Historical-Sociological Perspective on the History of Modern Rankings*). Their analyses of rankings quite explicitly dismantle the *illusio* of comparison's most foregrounded, in this case almost mathematically proven neutrality, while, at the same time, calling for a genealogy of the diverse historical forms of comparative practices. While opening up the competitive field of contemporary comparisons made easy by computers, the internet, algorithms, and artificial intelligence, *Where Do Rankings Come From?* reveals the agenda and the history of doing comparisons in general. By shaping and transforming the realities that comparisons pretend to just register and rearrange, practices of comparing make history in more than one sense: They are bound to specific historical media and technologies that transform comparative acts correspondingly, and they change the realities that they allegedly describe in a seemingly innocent comparative way.

The second part of the volume starts with a contribution by Gary Shaw that fills a whole unmarked chapter in the history of comparative practices (*The Weight of Comparing in Medieval England*). Until now, the history of comparisons and comparatisms has been traced back mostly to early modern and modern periods, thus implicitly falling back on the old notion of medieval times as a dark age that had seen neither the rise of individuality nor decisive encounters with non-European civilizations and the important cross-cultural comparisons they produce. Contrary

to this hardly contested notion, Gary Shaw draws on a broad picture of the role of medieval comparisons—from everyday practices such as weighing, selling, and buying on agricultural markets to the increasing importance of money for facilitating comparative acts on a daily basis. Furthermore, he highlights comparing as an administrative tool that easily expands to and fosters economic and political matters including questions of rank and clothing that actually permeate medieval societies on a very general basis. It is by no means incidental that Francis Bacon stretches the range of comparisons to the religious realm or that the warning against comparison—the saying that "comparisons are odious"—appears almost simultaneously in poetry and law in the fifteenth century, thus emphasizing the dynamics that made comparing a routinized practice but also a site of political and moral as well as legal and religious conflicts and contestations. Moreover, Shaw makes an important methodological point: He asks how the historian is able to trace comparative practices, even when these practices are not addressed explicitly in his sources. By taking into consideration different social, economic, and cultural fields, Shaw demonstrates that it is indeed possible to reconstruct comparative practices without relying on explicit documents alone.

In France, almost at the same time, history is another site of these contestations in which the act of comparing—according to Andrea Frisch—triggers epochal "transformative effects" precisely by being continued, taken to its very limits, and loaded with implicit underlying ambivalences and contradictions (*The Shifting Grounds of Comparison in the French Renaissance: The Case of Louis Le Roy*). The work of Louis le Roy in the sixteenth century is a quite telling case in point. Comparing civilizations—overall France with ancient Greece and Rome—is challenged as much by a third term such as Islam as by following subcomparisons and juxtapositions. Instead of clear-cut traditional worldviews and rankings, a lack of common ground starts to unsettle old notions of differences and sameness, while slowly indicating losses of historiographical standards that open up history (and its writing) in unforeseen directions.

This may also apply to larger cross-cultural comparisons—as Zhang Longxi explores in his contribution on the comparisons between Europe and China (*Comparison and East–West Encounters: The Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries*). Starting with the Renaissance and Marco Polo's travels, these comparisons, right from the beginning, did not just provide a tool to compare civilizations on an almost equal level of civilization in terms of culture, refined manners, and taste—thus creating resemblances and comparables on a large scale. The portraits of China in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries are also used to shift cultural difference from a reflection on one's own achievements to a medium of social critique addressing Europe itself.

Nonetheless, Asian countries and Far-Eastern civilizations remain a resource for imagining the other in numerous ways. As Emanuel Lozerand makes clear in his contribution on the European reports and fantasies on Japan from the fifteenth to

the twentieth century (*Japan as the Absolute Other: Geneology and Variations of a Topos*), Japan has served as an image and a projection of alterity throughout the centuries. Yet, the content of this mirror image and the implied comparative negotiations vary at great length due to the different comparative methods applied. From time to time, for example, in the eighteenth century (paralleling the cases of China and Japan on this point), differences were reduced and similarities gained ground. Yet, as Lozerand shows in great detail, the observed facts and the content of the respective comparisons often remained in place while the perspectives and the interpretations, the *tertia comparationis*, were shifted and changed, invented, and left behind. Therefore, former opposites turned into resemblances under a new heading, and the mirror image of Japan as a topsy-turvy version of Europe—up until Claude Lévi-Strauss—does not reveal a rigid structure (or stereotype) at all, but a very mobile comparative strategy with numerous variations and quite different purposes.

The range and contestations of comparative practices over the centuries extend not only geographically but also according to the modes and objects of knowing, the *episteme*, and scientific practices in general. As Leopold Ringel and Tobias Werron already showed in their contribution, art has a long history of rankings, but also developed as a field of its own in the seventeenth and eighteenth century. Artworks are utilized as a realm of taste and common sense (*sensus communis*). The "*je ne sais quoi*" as a quite common formula of the undefinable evaluation of beauty and art works in the seventeenth century leads to the emergence of the philosophical subdiscipline of "aesthetics" as an analysis of the lower capacities of mind in Alexander Gottlieb Baumgarten's *Aesthetica* (1750/58). But such theoretical or philosophical discourses eclipsed important practices, particularly practices of comparison that were established by connoisseurs, amateurs, and collectors. In his contribution (*'Goût de Comparison'. Practices of Comparative Viewing in Eighteenth-Century Connoisseurship*), Joris C. Heyder points to an important trajectory in the history of art when comparing became the very essence of judging artworks long before the comparative sciences also took hold of the institutionalized academic efforts of art criticism. When Jean-Baptist Dubos claimed a "*goût de comparison*" as the core method of judging the value of art in 1719, he was referring to taste and connoisseurship that mark not only a community of art critics but also a practice in front of paintings that was being remodeled and refined as well as continued up to the nineteenth century. The communities of connoisseurs doing and establishing specific patterns of comparing art gave way to academic practices in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries that often denigrated those comparing judgments as amateurish but nevertheless depended on similar criteria for their own comparative judgments.

As in art history, studying comparative practices in seemingly well-known topics such as the construction of the Other, theories of race, and practices of slavery

often challenges the established temporal, geographical, and theoretical scope of research. Angelika Epple in her contribution (*Inventing White Beauty, Fighting Black Slavery: Blumenbach's, Humboldt's, and Arango y Parreño's Share in Cuban Race Comparisons in the Long Nineteenth Century*) shows that the concept of race, however vague it used to be, has always been strongly combined with the discussion on slavery and "*limpieza de sangre*" (blood purity) ever since the sixteenth century. Around 1800, when Humboldt visited Cuba for the first time, race comparisons partly merged with new instruments of statistical population control. Humboldt's famous essay on Cuba became a seminal point of reference in Cuba and beyond—even in the US presidential election of 1856. The contribution traces how Humboldt was influenced not only by the Göttingen-based comparative anatomist, Johann von Blumenbach, but also by the Cuban slave owner, Arango y Parreño. Blumenbach, a committed abolitionist, tried to prove the equal roots of all races, and used this to derive equal rights for all humans. Arango y Parreño, in contrast, defended the Cuban way of slavery that—in his eyes—made Cuban slaves "the happiest in the world." The (comparative) question whether or not a better slavery existed undermined Humboldt's conviction that slavery was incomparable to other systems of violence. In addition, even though Humboldt mistrusted statistics, with his huge collection of data and supported by Arango y Parreño, he helped to establish the race comparisons by numbers that triggered conflicts in Cuba until the twentieth century.

The comparison of the "old" and "new" world, of race and matters of slavery and domination, as well as the temporalities of comparisons in terms of progress and development opens an arena in which different types of comparative situations come into play. Comparative practices are used widely either in situations of competition and conflict or in situations of negotiation, contact, and distinction. Comparative arguments in a site of conflict or negotiation can arise all of sudden, whereas comparative judgements might develop differently in situations in which they are reflected and contemplated retrospectively. The twentieth century as a much-disputed "age of extremes" might have seen a lot of comparative practices borne out of conflict and competition that were enhanced by capitalism and the market economy (as also outlined by the contribution of Leopold Ringel and Tobias Werron). As a specific case in point, Thomas Müller studies the politicization of comparisons in the realm of arms races and military competition between superpowers in the Cold War (*The Politicization of Comparisons: The East–West Dispute Over Military Force Comparisons in the Cold War*). As much as the politicization of comparisons of these comparisons depends on public disputes, the dynamic set forth by political actors could also alter the comparative framework, thus changing the whole situation and opening the way to either more conflict and competition or to a depoliticization of the whole debate.

Whereas the politicization of comparisons in the arenas of conflict and competition might be a dominant course in the twentieth century—often blurring the

boundaries between politics, economics, and moral issues—the modern and contemporary system of art seems to have developed as a sphere of its own in terms of its markets, its values, its critics, and its public. Yet, as Britta Hochkirchen clearly demonstrates in her contribution (*Genealogies of Modernism: Curatorial Practices of Comparing in the Exhibitions "Cubism and Abstract Art" and "Documenta I"*), comparisons do not only have their place in the evaluative judgments of spectators and art critics (as already developed with the practices of connoisseurship studied in Joris C. Heyder's contribution). However, by means of spatial arrangements and displays, exhibitions and presentations in museums themselves enable, stimulate, and perform comparisons. Hence, Hochkirchen's examples from the middle of the 20th century show that museums and exhibitions create their own narratives of modernism. By suggesting temporalities via the differences and similarities of artworks that inevitably carry implicit temporal indices, curators and art critics displayed those kinds of comparative settings and storylines that implied the corresponding framework of modernist history. Therefore, their practices induced a term and phenomenon such as "modernity" or "modernism" going far beyond just art history. By taking this approach, the chapter explicitly draws attention to interrelations between comparative practices and concepts or experiences of time.

Studying comparative practices in detail offers a different view on history in general. Whereas many well-established comparisons seem to draw on either dichotomies or on results of long-lasting developments, a closer look reveals a surprising complexity of short-ranged transformations, renegotiations, and historical change. The dynamics of comparative practices sometimes allow the compared objects, the *comparata*, to stay in place while the framework, the perspectives, and the *tertium comparationis* change implicitly. Or, vice versa, an established framework organizing the comparisons slowly relates the differences and similarities of the *comparata* in unforeseen new and different ways, thus changing the whole picture. Therefore, the analysis of the shifting, recalibrating, and changing of comparative practices does not just deepen and strengthen the way a relational history might operate without falling back on the assumption of seemingly strong binaries, entities, or dichotomies. It also delivers an insight into how historical change is about to happen on the microlevel of everyday comparative practices and discourses that range from the basic forms of perception, judging, and knowing to the structuring of reality; and it does this by discerning cultural patterns of differences and similarities between human beings, religions, morals, societies, or civilizations.

The contemporary digitalization, at the latest, has brought to mind that media and technologies contribute heavily to the formation and transformation of comparative practices—be it through new media such as money exchange (in Gary Shaw's example of the Middle Ages) or the printing press; or through numbers, graphs, statistics, or algorithms. Technologies change the way comparing is conducted on a daily basis, and they change the way we reconstruct the past and do

historical research. The final contribution in this volume by Anna Maria Neubert and Silke Schwandt (*Comparing in the Digital Age: About the Transformation of Practices*) presents an outlook on how contemporary and future comparative practices are being remodeled by digital devices. Again, comparing as a practice sets in motion an unpredictable dynamic that does not leave the *comparata* untouched and does not leave the frame of references in place. As much as digital analyses—as demonstrated by Neubert and Schwandt—will shed a new light and provide new research on the historical practices of comparing, this general "transformation" of relating and comparing objects of knowledge that is coming about through digitalization will also strongly influence our everyday practices of perceiving, learning, and knowing. Practices and patterns of comparing have shaped history in what were previously unknown ways; they will also go on to shape the future in many unpredictable ways as well.

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